

Narrative Writing: The Lighthouse Signal

Name: _____

Date: _____

Year 6 English — Writing

ACARA v9.0: AC9E6LY06

Learning Intention

I am learning to plan, draft and refine a narrative that builds tension and develops characters through action and dialogue.

Success Criteria

- I can plan a narrative with a clear structure (orientation, complication, resolution).
- I can build tension using pacing and description.
- I can develop a character through their actions and dialogue.

Show, Don't Just Tell

Instead of writing 'she was scared,' show it: 'Her hands trembled as she reached for the door.' Build tension through what characters do and say, not just what you tell the reader.

Worked Example

Told: The keeper was worried about the storm.

Shown: The keeper's eyes darted to the darkening sky, and his hand tightened around the lantern.

Part A — Planning

Prompt: A lighthouse keeper on a remote Australian coast sees a strange flashing light out at sea late one stormy night. Plan your narrative below.

Orientation: Who is your main character, and where/when is the story set?

Complication: What problem or mystery does the flashing light create?

Resolution: How does your character resolve the problem by the end?

Part B — Building Tension

Write a 'told' sentence about fear, then rewrite it as 'shown'.

Told:

Shown:

Write 2-3 lines of dialogue that reveal personality without stating it.

Describe the setting using a simile or metaphor to build atmosphere.

Write your story's final sentence — a strong final image or feeling.

Word Bank

orientation • complication • resolution • tension • dialogue • atmosphere • pacing

Working Space — Write Your Full Narrative Draft (Continue on the Back if Needed)

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Answer Key — Part A

A1: Student's own planning response — teacher to check structure and originality.

A2: Student's own response identifying character, setting time and place — teacher to check.

A3: Student's own response describing a clear complication linked to the flashing light — teacher to check.

A4: Student's own response showing a logical, satisfying resolution — teacher to check.

Part B

B1: Student's own 'told' and 'shown' sentence pair — teacher to check that the 'shown' version demonstrates feeling through action/description rather than stating it directly.

B2: Student's own dialogue — teacher to check that personality is revealed indirectly through word choice/tone, not stated outright.

B3: Student's own descriptive sentence using a simile or metaphor — teacher to check for correct figurative language use.

B4: Student's own final sentence — teacher to check it leaves a strong, deliberate final impression.

I Can Checklist

☐ I can plan a narrative with clear structure.

☐ I can develop character through action and dialogue.

☐ I can build tension through pacing and description.